

0-12 PAGES, Binghamton, N.Y. Wed., June 22, 1977

Tip to NY Times: No Chart on Zachry

The Wednesday Wash:

It does strain the brain to recall a New York ballclub's trade that approaches the Tom Seaver shuffle-off in failure to get equal value, especially g-a-t-e value. One Dodger, born in the 1950s probably, calls it "the biggest steal since Babe Ruth"—who in 1920 cost the Yankees \$125,000 and a \$335,000 mortgage on Fenway Park.

But one dandy challenger can't be blamed on M. Donald Grant or Dick Young was the then N.Y. Giants' dispatch of Rogers Hornsby to the Boston Braves prior to the 1928 season.

Rajah wasn't as old as Seaver and his batting average for the eight previous seasons was .382 (yes, THREE!). But Boston got him for an outfielder named Jimmy Welsh, whom the Giants kept only one year, and an immovable object named Shanty Hogan.

Hornsby was regarded as ornery, however (the Giants had acquired him for a song a year earlier, when St. Louis Cardinal management refused him a 2-year contract though he'd just managed World Series victory over the Murderers Row Yankees.)

When young Andy Cohen, who took over second base, proceeded to get off to a torrid start, one New York newspaper, the World, ran a daily gloat-with-us tabulation showing Cohen's average alongside what Hornsby was doing in Boston.

When Boston arrived in town, Hornsby growled, "That's a lousy trick that paper is playing on Cohen—I ain't hitting now, but when I start, I'll lose him." Which he did. And Cohen soon was playing in Elmira.

Rajah on his unmerry way to Chicago. The next year Farrell batted .215, Hornsby somewhere in the .380s again.

Seaver had been 189-110, in going on 10 years as a Met. Lefty Grove had just finished a six-year chore of 150-41 for the Athletics—long pre-Finley—when Connie Mack sent him to the Red Sox, one year older than Seaver.

He even threw in another southpaw who averaged more than 15 wins the same years, Rube Walberg, and a second-baseman who'd drawn 100 walks five straight seasons, Max Bishop—in return for which the Sox had to hand over \$125,000 in 1933 currency, a shortstop with a lifetime batting average below .215 and a pitcher who would be forever gone from the majors the same season.

Barney Nagler expresses Joe Torre's dilemma, with so great a pitcher but so unhappy a team leader, in a manner befitting a Daily Racing Form columnist:

"That recalls a story told by Joe Palmer about the

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jockey who was asked to go down to Texas to ride in a quarter horse race. When he refused, despite a sizable financial inducement, a friend asked him why.

"Did it once," said the rider, "but no more. I went down to ride a horse at El Paso. On the way from the shed that we used as a jockey room in the saddling paddock, a big Texan stopped me. 'Son,' he said, pulling his coat back far enough to show the butt of a big gun under his arm, 'You'd better not win this race. I'm betting a lot of money against you.'"

"Then the rider moved toward his mount, at which time the owner pulled back his coat and displayed just as big a gun. 'Son,' the owner said, 'I'm betting a lot of money on this horse. You'd better win this one.'"

"So," said the jockey, 'I don't ride no more quarter horses.'"

DAVE BLISS, REALLY "in the running" for the UCLA basketball job?

Longshot as it may seem, with a .500 record for his 2-year career as a head coach (Oklahoma U.), nomination of the clean-scrubbed young Binghamton Central grad gains credence. Give a listen to Oregon's Dick Harter (who is more conspicuously a possibility—Oregon 2-0 over UCLA last winter), who prefaces his analysis with suggestion that the "inside-track" being accorded former John Wooden aide Gary Cunningham is only a smokescreen:

"It just might be a bide-time situation for J.D. Morgan (UCLA athletic director). My guess is that he already knows the three or four guys he wants to talk to." (Bliss, now happy at University of Oklahoma but not slamming the phone down, admits that one of Morgan's associates called to make small-to-middlin' talk as soon as it became evident Clean Gene Bartow wanted out from under that legend on his back.)

"Whoever they hire, they've got to hire a guy who just doesn't care, a guy who goes in and tells the critics, 'This is the way I do things, period.' It will take either a guy with a tremendous ego, or a guy who is determined to take a 5-year contract and ride it out, who is willing to take whatever (criticism) is given to him."

REGGIE AND BILLY? I like Jerry Izenberg's analysis—"When four egos live within two men, it is bound to get crowded."

HUBIE GREEN? In Dave Hill's new book, "Teed Off", the section on the 1977 U.S. Open champion says, "Today he can play because his nerves are great. If he ever wakes up one morning and asks himself what the game's all about, he's in a bunch of trouble." Not as much as if he wakes up at night and asks himself what death threats are all about?

SHORT SNORTS: Money still talks louder than hay and Seattle Slew's promised rest until Saratoga's late-August Travers Stakes now has been called off. Washington Park hiked its Swaps Purse figure on Fourth of July weekend from \$200,000 and he's in, and will also probably run at Monmouth... Oddity on Jimmy the Greek's early-line Super Bowl foes—the Rams and Raiders: both have Alabama grads as No. 1 quarterback (Namath and Stabler), Southern Cal grads at No. 2 QB (Pat Haden and Mike Ray) and ex-Nebraskas at No. 3 (Vince Ferragamo and Dave Humm)... Richie Karl had been expected to make his 1977 PGA-tour bow in Monday's Western Open qualifier, but Chicago scoreboard didn't show the Endicott's name. He's now apparently living in Iowa, ironic since the only tournaments in which he's lasted 72 holes in the last 26 months have been two B.C. Opens here and two Quad-Cities Opens there...

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